

Session 14: Laban Deceives Jacob

Key Takeaways

- Human favoritism is a distorted version of God's love and favor for the chosen one, which is bestowed for the blessing of the many.
- Yaaqov, with his four wives, is the furthest yet from the Eden ideal for marriage.
- God institutes laws protecting the firstborn's rights against favoritism, but God also loves to topple hierarchies to elevate the unloved and non-chosen.

Lavan the Deceiver, Rakhel and Leah the Trees

¹² And Yaaqov **told** **Rakhel** that he was **the brother of her father**, and that he was **the son of Rebekah**, then she **ran** and **told** her father.

¹³ And it came about when Lavan **heard** the **report** of Yaaqov, **son of his sister**, then he **ran** to meet him, and he embraced him, and he kissed him, and he brought him into his house, and he **reported** to Lavan all of these words.

¹⁴ And Lavan said to him, "Truly, **you are my bone and my flesh**!" And he dwelt with him **a month of days** (חדש ימים).

Genesis 29:12-14. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Lavan's Proposal

¹⁵ And Lavan said to Yaaqov,
A "Are you really **my brother**,
yet you serve me for nothing?
Tell me, what is your wage?"

Lavan's Daughters

B 16 Now, Lavan had two daughters,
the name of **the big one** was **Leah** [= "Cow"],
and the name of **the small one** was **Rakhel** [= "Lamb"].
17 Now, **the eyes** of **Leah** were **tender** ,
and **Rakhel** was **beautiful of form**
and **beautiful of sight** .

Proposal Implemented

18 And Yaaqov **loved Rakhel** ,
and he said,
"I will **serve** you **seven years** for **Rakhel** , your **smaller** daughter,
19 And Lavan said,
A' "It is more **good** that I **give** her to you,
than **giving** her to another man.
Dwell with me!"
20 And Yaaqov **served** for **Rakhel** for **seven years** ,
and they were **in his eyes** like **a few days** (ימים אחדים),
because of his **love** for her.

Lavan Gives the Wrong Daughter + a Slave

21 And Yaaqov said to Lavan,
" **Give** me my wife,
because **my days** are **fulfilled** ,
so I can go into her ."
22 And Lavan gathered all the men of **the place** ,
A and he made a drinking-feast,
23 **and it came about in the evening** ,
then he **took Leah** his daughter,
and he brought her to him,
and he went into her .
24 And Lavan **gave** Zilpah his female slave to **Leah** his daughter as a female slave.

Lavan's Deception Exposed

25 **And it came about in the morning** ,
and look: She was **Leah** !
And he said to Lavan,
" **What is this you have done to me** ?!
Didn't I **serve** you for **Rakhel** ?
So **why did you deceive me** ?!"

26 And Lavan said,
 “This is not how it’s done in **our place** ,
 to give **the little one** before the **firstborn** .
 27 **Fulfill this seven** ,
 then I will **give** to you also this one for the **service** ,
 which you will **serve** with me still **another seven years** .”

Lavan Gives the Right Daughter + a Slave

28 And Yaaqov did this,
 and he **fulfilled this seven** ,
 and he **gave** to him **Rakhel** his daughter for him as a wife.
 29 And Lavan **gave** to **Rakhel** his daughter Bilhah his female slave as her female slave.
 30 And he also went into **Rakhel** ,
 and he also **loved Rakhel** more than **Leah** ,
 and he **served** him still **another seven years** .

Genesis 29:15-30. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Following the scenes in Genesis 28:10-22 and Genesis 29:1-14, which both mapped onto the creation of Eden story and the provision of a partner for the lonely human, we now hear the next notes of the melody: the deception, a test, and the failure. This entire story is mapped onto the narrative pattern of Genesis 3.

Lavan's Deception in the East	The Snake's Deception in Eden of the East
Gen. 29:16-19 Two daughters in Lavan's family • Leah's eyes are "tender" (<i>rak</i> /רַך) • Rakhel is "beautiful of sight/form" (<i>יפה מראה</i> / תאר) • "It is more good (<i>טוב</i>) that I give her to you ..."	Gen. 3:6-7 Two trees in the garden • The forbidden tree is about knowing good (<i>טוב</i>) and bad (<i>רע</i> / <i>ra'</i>) • The forbidden tree is "good of sight and desirable to the eyes" (<i>טוב מראה</i> / <i>לעינים</i>)
Gen. 29:23 Lavan deceptively "takes" (<i>לקח</i>) the older daughter and "gives" (<i>נתן</i>) her to Yaaqov.	Gen. 3:6 The woman "took" (<i>לקח</i>) the fruit from the tree and she ate, then she "gave" (<i>נתן</i>) to her husband and he ate.
Gen. 29:25 After realizing the deception, Yaaqov says, "What is this you have done to me?!" (<i>מה זאת עשית לי</i>)	Gen. 3:13 After the humans are deceived and disobey God's command, God says, "What is this you have done?" (<i>מה זאת עשית</i>)
Gen. 29:26-30 Lavan's deception results in "service/slavery" (<i>עבד</i>) to Lavan for 2x7 years.	Gen. 3:23 The deception results in "slavery" (<i>עבד</i>) to the ground until death.

Lavan the Snake. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Also important is how the three stories of Abraham and Yitskhaq putting their wives at risk are being drawn upon for the analogy between the daughters and the trees.

Genesis 2-3	Genesis 12	Genesis 20
Gen. 3:6 And the woman (האשה) saw (ראה) that good (טוב) was the tree for eating, and desirable to the eyes ... and she took (לקח) ...	Gen. 12:11-12 I know (ידע) that a woman (אשה) beautiful of sight (מראה) you are ... and they will see you (ראה) ... and kill me and let you live (הוה)	Gen. 20:2 Abraham said of Sarah, "She is my sister." And Abimelech king of Gerar sent and took (לקח) Sarah.
Gen. 2:17 From the tree of knowing good and bad you must not eat, because in the day you eat from it, you will certainly die (מות תמות).		Gen. 20:3 Look, you are dead (מת), on account of the woman whom you took . Gen. 20:7 ... and if you don't return her, do that you will certainly die (מות תמות) ...
Gen. 3:3 From the tree that is in the middle of the garden we cannot eat from it or touch it (נגע)	Gen. 12:17 And Yahweh touched/struck (נגע) Pharaoh with touches/strikes (נגעים)	Gen. 20:6 God said to him ... "I did not allow you to touch/strike (נגע)"
Gen. 3:9 And Yahweh called out to (ויקרא) the man ... Gen. 3:13 And Yahweh said to the woman, " What is this you have done (מה זאת עשית)?"	Gen. 12:18 And Pharaoh called out to (ויקרא) Abram and said, " What is this you have done (מה זאת עשית) to me? You didn't tell (נגד) me that she was your wife."	Gen. 20:9 Abimelech called out to (ויקרא) Abraham and said, " What have you done to us (מה עשית לנו)?"
Gen. 2:16 And Yahweh commanded (ויצו) the human ... Gen. 3:23 And Yahweh sent	Gen. 12:20 And Pharaoh commanded (ויצו) ... and sent him away (שלח).	Gen. 20:15 And Abimelech said, "Behold, my land is before you, dwell (ישב) in the good in your eyes (טוב בעיניך)."
<i>Wives at Risk.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).		

Genesis 2-3	Genesis 12	Genesis 20
away (שלח) the human from the garden of Eden.		
Gen. 3:5 ... in the day that you eat from it your eyes (עיניכם) will be opened ...		Gen. 20:16 One thousand silver pieces ... let it be as a covering of the eyes (כסות עינים) for you.
Wives at Risk. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).		

In all of these stories, a snake-like deceiver takes what God has given as a blessing (trees/a wife), and twists it into a violation of God’s command and promise.

- In Genesis 3, the snake deceived a husband and wife about a forbidden tree.
- In Genesis 12, 20, and 26, the husband acts like a deceitful snake about a forbidden wife.
- In Genesis 29, the father acts like a deceitful snake about his daughters and uses them to co-opt for himself the blessing of God’s chosen one.

That’s Not How We Do Things Around Here

Recall Yaaqov’s long conversations with the shepherds in Genesis 29:4-8 and the seemingly random focus on the eastern shepherds’ normal custom of waiting to water their sheep until all the flocks are gathered (Gen. 29:1-3) and not before (as they say to Yaaqov in Gen. 29:7-8). There is a significant effort made by the author to recall those themes here in this panel about Lavan’s deception and Yaaqov’s marriage to his daughters.

Genesis 29:1-11

- **29:3-6** The shepherds who know Lavan gather by the well with the “stone ... **in its (מקום) place.**”
- **29:3, 8** They **gather (אסף) all the flocks** by the well and then can provide **drinking water (שקה)** to the flocks.
- **29:10-11** Yaaqov barges ahead to water the flock (וישק) and to kiss (וישק) **Rakhel**.
- **29:8** **“We are not able [to water the flock] until all the herds are gathered.** That’s when we water the flock.”

Genesis 29:12-14

- “And Rakhel ran and reported this to her father”
- “And Yaaqov reported all these things to Lavan”

Genesis 29:15-30

- **29:22** The men who come to Yaaqov’s wedding are called “**the men of the place (מקום)**”.
- **29:22** “Lavan **gathered (אסף) the men** of the place and he made a **drinking feast (משתה)** for them.”
- **29:18** Yaaqov assumes he can ask to marry **Rakhel**, the younger daughter, before Leah, the older daughter
- **29:25-26** Yaaqov: “Why did you deceive me?!”
Lavan: “**That’s not how things are done in our place (מקום),** to give the little one before the firstborn.”

Genesis 29:1-30. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

These repetitions use deliberate strategy to compare Yaaqov’s brash behavior with Rakhel and the flocks with his equally brash request to marry the younger daughter before the older.

The role of the shepherds and the men of the place are exactly parallel: both are present at the two “drinking” sources in the story (a well and a drinking party).

And Lavan and the shepherds play the same role: to inform Yaaqov that “That’s now how we do things around here in Kharan!”

Yaaqov's role as the trickster and manipulator in his own family may have brought him success up to a point, but now that he’s swimming in a bigger pond, he finds that his old tricks don’t work so well anymore.

Deceptions Within Deceptions: “The One Who Digs a Pit Falls Into It ...”

The narrative of Yaaqov in exile has been designed as an elaborate exploration of the theme in Proverbs about how the schemes of the wicked always come back upon them.

Proverbs 26:24-27 Instructor's Translation

²⁴ Whoever **hates,** he **disguises himself** with his lips,
and harbors **deception** **in his heart;**

²⁵ when he speaks with generous grace,
do not believe him,
for seven abominations **in his heart;**

²⁶ although his **hatred** is covered with **trickery,**
his evil will be exposed in the assembly.

²⁷ Whoever digs a pit will fall into it,
and **whoever rolls a stone, it will turn back onto him.**

This proverb is a classic statement of the biblical “eye for eye” model of recompense: Whatever you’ve done to others will eventually make its way back to you. Notice how in this first story of Lavan’s deception, he does to Yaaqov exactly what Yaaqov did to his family members.

Lavan’s deception contains the main features of Yaaqov and Rivqah’s deception.

- Rakhel is the younger sibling, favored by Yaaqov // Yaaqov is the younger sibling, loved by Rivqah and chosen by God
- Leah is the older sibling, unloved by Yaaqov // Esau is the older sibling, loved by Yitskhaq, non-chosen by God
- Yaaqov deceives Esau to get the “firstborn right” // Lavan deceives Yaaqov with his firstborn daughter
- Yaaqov's deception earned him the blessing // Lavan’s deception inverts the blessing into slavery
- Lavan's deception also uses key words and themes from the Yaaqov story: disguising oneself, deception, trickery, seven, and rolling a stone.

Reflection Question

How is Lavan’s deception at Yaaqov’s wedding a distorted version of Eden blessing and a reversal of Yaaqov’s own deceptions?